bring down unemployment rate in the state from about 10 per cent in March 2020 to about 4 per cent in June 2021 due to the extensive skill-mapping exercise it carried out for the returning migrants and further linking them to potential employers. The UP government provided about 39 metric tonnes of free ration during the second wave which works out to be about 100 kg per family, thus ensuring that the most populous state in India does not go hungry. Availability of COVID-19 beds was increased by 80,000 beds and healthcare manpower was significantly augmented to address the surge in cases. A COVID-19 monitoring committee was set up in every village equipped with a basic medical kit which could be given to anyone suspected to be infected. Timely restrictions on movement was key to UP's success in controlling the second wave. IIT's report shows that the lockdown was so timely that had it been done earlier, it wouldn't have contributed to reduction in caseload but would have significantly crippled the state's economy and any delay would have led to quick multiplication of cases. To keep an eagle's eye on the oxygen supply, the state had set up a 78-member team which constantly monitored the 15 oxygen plants which supplied oxygen to UP along with 133 oxygen tankers tagged with GPS and RFID which moved oxygen from them to various parts of the state.

Coupled with the negative atmosphere countrywide, with no sight of emerging out of the wave and stories of despair and gloom plastered all over the media, the opposition began to blame the prime minister for the state of affairs. The fact that the former BJP chief minister of Uttarakhand Tirath Singh Rawat encouraged people to come to the Kumbha Mela in huge numbers only added to the resentment towards the prime minister. To top this, images of the prime minister addressing large rallies in West Bengal, fuelled the fire. After what they appreciated in the first wave, people expected the prime minister to get the house in order, even if it required a heavy hand. His decision to give autonomy to states began to be considered his weakness. His staunchest loyalists became disenchanted with his approach to handling the second wave and naturally his approval ratings dropped drastically.

The Opposition began to build on this mood. After all, why would they lose an opportunity to malign the leader responsible for their political